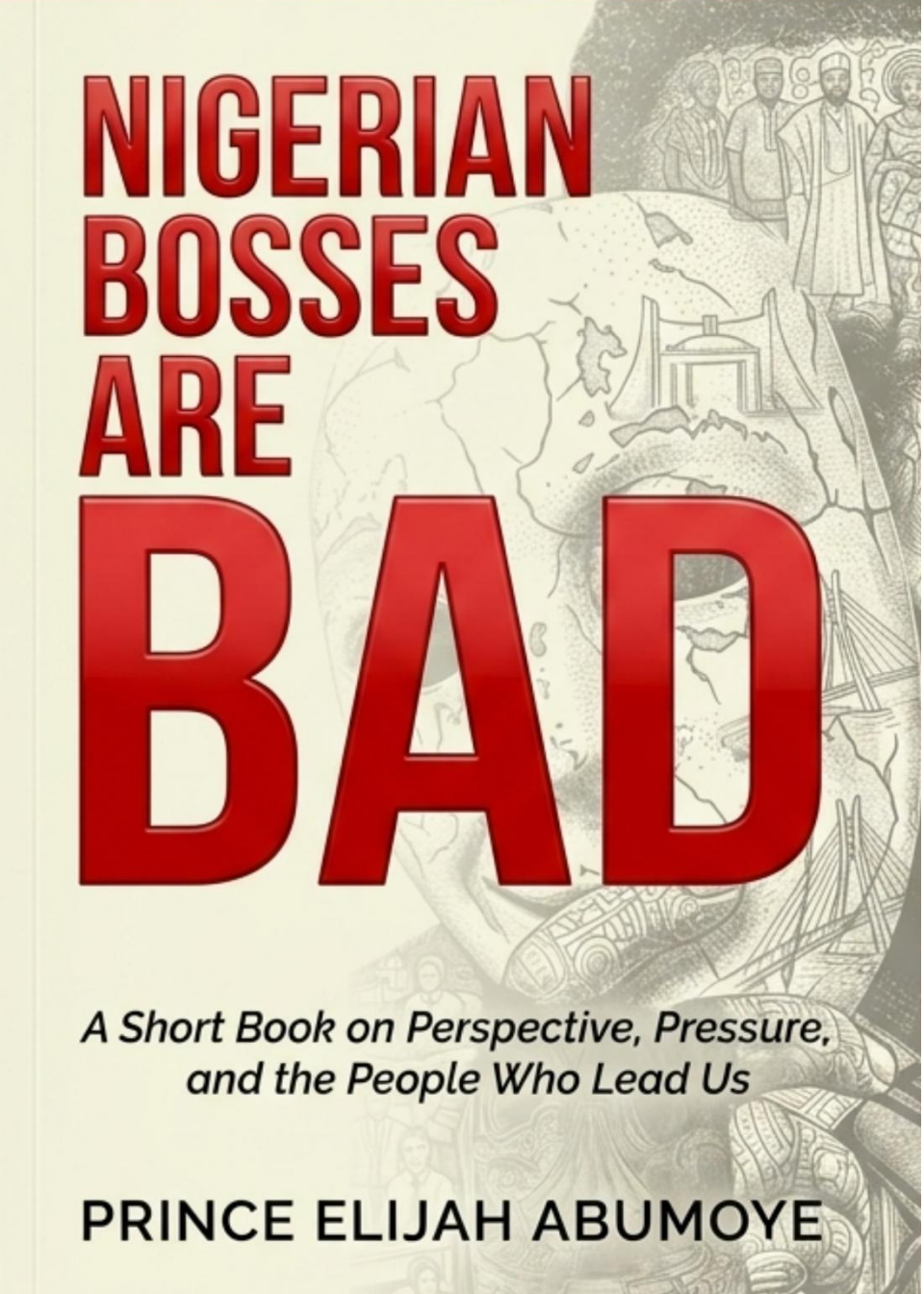


The background of the book cover is a detailed, light-colored collage. It features a map of Nigeria, a traditional Nigerian building (possibly a palace or temple), a bridge, and several figures in traditional Nigerian attire. The collage is rendered in a sketch-like, etched style.

NIGERIAN BOSSSES ARE BAD

*A Short Book on Perspective, Pressure,
and the People Who Lead Us*

PRINCE ELIJAH ABUMOYE

Nigerian Bosses Are Bad

Written by Prince Elijah Abumoye



*A Short Book on Perspective, Pressure, and the People Who Lead
Us*



Foreword

Hello, my name is Prince Elijah Abumoye. I am an HR and Business consultant based in Nigeria, and I have worked with over 50 businesses since we birthed Traction Outsourcing Limited. I started my 9-5 journey in Lagos mainland, and the yellow buses are my good friends. In fact, one time while in university, I had to double as a bus conductor because there weren't enough seats, and I was not sure of the next bus. For the most part of this book, I am sharing experiences I have either witnessed while consulting, working, or mentoring young people as they build their careers.

Somewhere in Lagos tonight, somebody is typing a resignation letter at 11 p.m. They will save it in drafts. They will not send it, because rent does not care how you feel about your Oga, and neither does the landlord who is already asking for next quarter before this one has ended.

If you have worked under a Nigerian boss, you have said it at least once. Maybe under your breath in the office toilet. Maybe into your phone on the drive home. "This one is wicked." "That woman does not have human blood." "How can somebody treat people like this?"

You are not the only one who has thought about it. The marketer denied compassionate leave while her father lay in a hospital bed. The team lead queried for arriving fifteen minutes



late on the one morning Lagos flooded so badly a popular big man's convoy got stuck. The designer whose campaign was presented to the client by her boss, without once mentioning her name. Every one of these stories sounds specific until you realize how many people are nodding along, because it happened to them too, with different names attached.

It would be easy to write a book that simply confirms what you already suspect: that something is broken in the Nigerian boss, that cruelty gets learned somewhere between the interview and the big office and never gets unlearned. That book would sell. People love being told they were right to be angry. This is not quite that book, though the anger gets its full due first.

Six chapters follow. Each one opens with somebody you'll probably recognize, under a boss doing something that looks, on the surface, exactly like malice. A man who never says thank you. A woman who cannot hold a decision steady for a week. A boss who counts naira like it's the last he'll ever see, works you through a wedding, or keeps you circling the same desk no matter how far you've clearly outgrown it. One chapter, the one about power and who gets trusted with it, does not get the same treatment as the rest. I'll tell you why when you get there.

Past the halfway point of each chapter, I step in myself. Not to forgive anybody in advance. Some of what you'll read here really is just bad character, and I am not going to dress that up as market pressure. But a surprising amount of it, in the businesses



I've actually sat inside, has a cash flow problem or a bad hire or a founder's own fear sitting underneath it, quietly explaining a decision that looked, from the staff's side of the desk, like pure spite.

By the end, you probably still won't like your boss more. That was never the plan. What changes, if this book does its job, is the shape of the question you ask afterward. Not just "why is this person like this," but something with a little more use in it.

I don't say any of this from a distance. I've missed weekends of my own chasing a client deadline. I've had to look a good staff member in the eye and tell them not now, for reasons I hadn't fully worked out myself yet. Nobody runs a business in this country without becoming, at some point, at least one of the bosses in this book. That's not an excuse I'm handing anyone in advance. It's just the truth I'm writing from.

Let's start with the anger. It's earned, and it isn't going anywhere just because a few pages ask it to sit down.



Chapter One

The Boss Who Never Says "Well Done"



1

The Boss Who Never Says "Well Done"

Ifeoma worked two years in that Apapa logistics office before she said it out loud: "*That man does not know how to appreciate anybody.*" She had just saved the company four million naira in demurrage, two weeks of cross-checking bills of lading, calls at 7 a.m. to catch a clearing agent before he switched his phone off, three nights till 9 p.m. fixing what other people's mistakes had broken.

Her boss read the report the next morning and said, "Make sure it doesn't happen again next quarter." No handshake. Nothing.

Ask around any office in Lagos, Abuja, or Port Harcourt and you'll find her twin in nearly every department: the accountant who found the discrepancy nobody else caught, the driver who nursed a dying van across three states to beat a deadline, each one met afterward with something less than a nod.

Some of this really is what it looks like. There are bosses whose silence is contempt plain and simple, who see people as fuel to be burned rather than colleagues to be thanked. If that's



genuinely what you're looking at, nothing in this chapter should talk you out of it.

But Mr. Adisa built that logistics company from two trucks in 2011 to a fleet of twenty-six. He built it through 2016, when the naira lost close to forty percent of its value in a matter of months and spare parts doubled in price overnight. Through 2020, when half the transport companies around him in Apapa folded, and he had to choose more than once between paying his drivers and paying himself. A friend of his, running a similar outfit, expanded fast after one good year, hired generously, and let the team enjoy itself. The recession arrived a few months later and finished what the celebration had started. Mr. Adisa was at that man's warehouse sale, watching trucks he used to admire get auctioned off for parts.

Praise, to a man carrying that memory, isn't withheld out of cruelty. It's withheld because somewhere along the way he decided that telling a team "Well done" is the same as telling them it's safe to slow down, and in the kind of economy he's survived, slowing down is how a company ends up at its own warehouse sale. He isn't managing Ifeoma. He's managing what he survived before he ever met her.

I've sat across the table from bosses like this more times than I can count, and here's what most people get wrong about them. Withholding praise isn't always about the person standing in



front of you. Sometimes it's about a number that refuses to move no matter what the person in front of you does.

I once sat in on a review meeting where a CEO asked his social media manager a plain question: how many sales had her posts actually brought in that month. She went quiet. She had reach, followers, comments, likes, everything she'd been trained to call a result. None of it had a naira value attached, and she had never once been asked to attach one. He wasn't trying to embarrass her. He was a small business owner watching an account stay dry while a member of staff sat comfortably under the office AC, doing real work by her own measure, work that never once touched the bottom line. When she came back the following month with the same kind of report, he did not say well done, because nothing in that report had told him the business was any safer than it had been thirty days earlier.

That is usually the first sign I look for when a business calls me in. Not that the owner is heartless. That nobody has ever sat down and connected what a role actually does to what the business actually needs, so praise has nowhere honest to land. Fix that gap and the "well done" problem tends to fix itself, because now there's something true to say it about.

None of that makes Ifeoma's hurt smaller. Recognition is a real need, not a soft one, and a manager who never gives it is gambling with something real: burnout, quiet resentment, a team that eventually stops handing over its best work because



nobody seems to notice the difference anyway. Some of Nigeria's sharpest people are leaving right now, in the wave everyone calls Japa, partly because a firm three time zones away has figured out that "thank you" costs nothing and buys quite a lot.

So, if your boss is one of these, ask the harder question before you file him under wickedness. Is the silence about you, or about a number he still doesn't know how to move? The answer changes what you do next. If it's the first, nothing here should keep you standing there waiting to be seen. If it's the second, there's often more room than you'd expect simply to ask what the number actually is, and whether what you're doing is the thing that moves it.



Chapter **Two**

The Boss Who Changes Her Mind Every Monday





The Boss Who Changes Her Mind Every Monday

Tunde had a private nickname for his CEO within six months of joining the fintech in Yaba. He called her NEPA. Her instructions took light like PHCN, here now, gone before you'd finished adjusting to it.

The product roadmap that was locked on Monday was scrapped by Wednesday. A payment-processor deal he'd spent three weeks negotiating died two days before signing, killed by a text that said only, it's not the right time anymore. He'd stay up getting a set of wireframes exactly right, proud of the work, and two days later learn none of it would ship.

There is a version of this story where Amaka is simply indecisive, a founder who talks a confident game in pitch decks and falls apart the moment a real decision needs holding. That version isn't entirely wrong.

It also isn't the whole picture. Amaka runs a fintech company inside a regulatory environment where the Central Bank can issue a circular on a Tuesday morning that makes Monday's entire business model illegal by lunchtime. Her cloud



infrastructure is billed in dollars, and the naira has a habit of losing double digits against it inside a single quarter. A plan that survives an entire quarter unchanged, in that climate, isn't proof of strong leadership. It's often proof that nobody was watching closely enough.

She watched a rival fintech refuse to adjust its lending model after a 2022 tightening. The founders were proud of their conviction. Eight months later the company didn't exist. What looks like flip-flopping from Tunde's desk looks, from hers, like a captain adjusting sail because the wind actually changed, in a sea considerably rougher than the one most leadership books were written for.

I worked with a nine-person logistics startup in Ogun State whose founder changed the delivery pricing model four times in one quarter. His operations lead, easily his best hire, started missing deadlines on purpose, not out of laziness but because he'd stopped trusting that whatever he built that week would still matter the following one. When I finally got the founder to walk me through his reasoning, it turned out every single change had a real cause: a fuel price jump, a competitor undercutting him on the same route, a rider strike that forced a rethink of the whole zone map. Every change was defensible. Not one of them had ever been explained to the operations lead. He'd been reacting to ghosts nobody told him existed.



We didn't fix the pricing model. We fixed the five-minute conversation that was supposed to happen every time it changed, and didn't.

Still, Tunde's frustration is not imaginary, and no circular from the Central Bank makes it disappear. People cannot pour their best work into a plan they suspect is dead by Friday, and he has already started holding something back on new projects, because throwing his whole self at work that keeps getting cancelled has begun to feel foolish. Amaka doesn't get to wave that cost away just by pointing at an exchange rate graph.

The line between adapting wisely and simply being erratic comes down to one thing: does she say why. Silence followed by a new plan is what turns adaptation into chaos, and chaos is what eventually sends good people like Tunde quietly updating their CVs on a Sunday night.

If you're working for someone like Amaka, find out, gently, whether the reasons exist and simply never get said out loud. Sometimes they do, and one honest question in a one-on-one opens the door. Sometimes there's no reason at all, and no amount of patient asking will produce one. Telling those two situations apart is most of the actual skill here.



Chapter **Three**

The Boss Who Counts Every Naira



3

The Boss Who Counts Every Naira

"Correction fluid? Why do we need this? Use fresh paper." Mrs. Ponzing did not look up from the requisition form as she said it. Two packs of printer paper in one week instead of one earned Blessing an actual conversation, complete with a request for an itemized explanation. Everyone at the boutique in Galadimawa called her Mama Naira behind her back, and by the time Blessing had worked there three years, the joke had curdled into something closer to a permanent verdict on the woman's character.

The worst of it, for Blessing, was the fabric supplier. A slightly better one existed, eight thousand naira more per bale, but reliable, no torn edges, no late deliveries. Mrs. Ponzing said no. She always said no to the better, costlier option, and Blessing had started to wonder whether the woman cared about the clothes at all, or only about the account balance sitting behind them.

Some bosses really are like this. Miserly by character rather than by necessity, capable of easy generosity and simply choosing not to extend it. If that's the boss you have, no paragraph about interest rates should talk you out of what you're actually seeing.



Mrs. Ponzing started her business in 2014 with a loan at nineteen percent annual interest, the only capital available to a woman with no collateral beyond her own reputation. Her materials are priced in dollars somewhere upstream no matter how Nigerian the finished garment looks, and she has watched those costs double, then double again, with each currency shock. There is no overdraft facility waiting patiently for her. One late-paying wholesaler, one delayed shipment, and forty tailors lose their income inside a week. Against all that, correction fluid and a second pack of paper are among the very few things she can actually control.

Most of the small businesses I advise are exactly this size, under fifty staff, running on a cash position the owner can recite from memory because there is no finance department to recite it for them. A colleague once told me he sat with a printing company owner in Sky Memorial - Abuja who wouldn't approve a new toner cartridge until the old one was scraped completely dry, even though the delay was costing him two rush jobs a month. When he finally ran the numbers with the owner, the two lost jobs were worth more than a year's worth of toner. He wasn't protecting the business by waiting. He was protecting a feeling of control, and the feeling was costing him real money.

That's the useful distinction, and it's not the one most people reach for. It isn't stingy versus generous. It's whether the boss can tell the difference between a naira that's actually protecting the business and a naira that's just protecting his nerves. Mrs.



Ponzing, watching the fabric market jump thirty percent overnight in 2023, closed the boutique for a day, sat with three months of receipts, and re-quoted every open order before reopening. Two clients walked over the new prices. She let them go without argument. That was the first kind of discipline. Refusing the better, more reliable fabric supplier over eight thousand naira a bale, while losing repeat customers to torn edges and late deliveries, was the second. One protected forty jobs. The other was quietly starving the business she was trying to save.

I've watched the same test play out with a bakery owner in Kuje who refused, for two years, to buy a second industrial mixer even though her one machine was the reason she turned down every large order above a certain size. She wasn't wrong to be careful. A second mixer was real money, and she'd watched a neighbouring bakery overextend on equipment and shut within a year. But she'd never actually run the numbers on what the missed orders were costing her, because running the numbers meant confronting how much bigger the business could already be, and some owners find it easier to live inside a smaller, safer version of their own company than to test whether the bigger one holds up. Running the numbers, she would later realize that the mixer paid for itself in five months. She still tells people she was being careful. She wasn't. She was being afraid, and calling it careful, which is the thing almost every business owner in her category has done about something, usually more than once.



The useful question was never really why she is so stingy. It's where exactly she draws the line, and whether that line is protecting the business or slowly bleeding it.



Chapter **Four**

The Boss Who Works You on Saturday



4

The Boss Who Works You on Saturday

Suraj had already bought the agbada fabric. He had already told his mother he was coming to Kwara. His cousin's traditional wedding was two days away.

At 6 p.m. on Friday, Engineer Jude called an emergency meeting. The client wanted revised drawings by Monday morning. Everybody in the office. Tomorrow.

Suraj spent that Saturday at his desk instead. It was not the first weekend the office had taken from him that year.

The Nigerian boss who eats into weekends is one of the most familiar villains going, and the resentment runs deep for a simple reason: money can be replaced, a missed wedding cannot. Burnout among young professionals in Lagos and Abuja is not invented, and a workplace culture that treats Saturday as an unofficial sixth working day does real, lasting damage to health, to marriages, to the family ties that hold a lot of Nigerian life together.

Jude's consultancy survives on being the firm that delivers when it says it will, in an industry full of clients who've been



burned by contractors who miss deadlines or vanish mid-project with a deposit. A missed Monday is not a small inconvenience to him. It can mean losing the client to whichever of the three serious rival firms in the state happens to be hungrier that quarter. There's no second team behind his first one. No slack built into the schedule, because a bid with slack in it loses to a rival's tighter, cheaper promise. So, when a client's specifications arrive late, the shock has nowhere to land except the weekend, because nowhere else in the system has any give left in it.

There was this twelve-person architecture firm in Ikoyi where every single project ran on this exact pattern, and the founder genuinely could not see it as a pattern. To him, each Saturday was its own emergency, unconnected to the last one. When we mapped a full year of his projects side by side, eleven of his last fourteen weekend call-ins traced back to the same root cause: he was quoting timelines to win the bid, not timelines the work could actually survive. He wasn't a slave driver by instinct. He was a founder who had never once separated "what will make the client say yes" from "what my team can actually deliver without breaking," and every Saturday was that gap finally showing up at the office.

He was able to rebid three live projects with honest timelines built in. He lost one of them to a cheaper, faster promise from a competitor. The other two closed with fewer surprises and a team that was still standing at the end of them.



That explains the pattern. It doesn't make the pattern healthy. A firm that survives on emergency Saturdays isn't resilient, it's fragile, quietly spending down the health and the relationships of the people keeping it running, until they leave, or break, or simply stop caring long before they officially resign.

There's a difference worth naming between the boss who calls two emergency Saturdays a year because something genuinely unpredictable landed on his desk, and the boss who has built weekend work into the culture as the default, reaching for "the client needs it" every time because admitting the business runs too close to the edge would mean fixing something harder than a deadline. If you work for someone like Jude, ask plainly: is this Saturday truly urgent, or has urgent quietly become how things always work here?

I ask every founder I work with the same question early on: how many of your last ten weekend emergencies actually needed to be emergencies, and how many were a normal Tuesday problem that simply arrived late and got treated like a fire because nobody had built a process for handling it any other way. Most founders have never counted. When they finally do, the number is almost always smaller than they expected, and smaller than the number of weekends their staff actually lost.



Chapter **Five**

The Boss Who Controls Through Fear



5

The Boss Who Controls Through Fear

Adaeze had been at the accounting firm in Ikeja four years when the branch manager role opened. She'd trained two of the partners' junior hires herself. She knew the client files better than anyone in the building.

Oga Segun gave the role to his nephew, six months into the firm and still asking basic questions about client onboarding. When Adaeze pushed back, carefully, in a one-on-one, Segun's voice went up before she'd finished her second sentence. "You question me now? In my own company?" The rest of that meeting she doesn't remember clearly. She remembers the volume, and she remembers leaving without having said the second half of what she came to say.

It wasn't the first time. Junior staff had learned to schedule bad news for late Friday, when Segun was already thinking about the weekend and less likely to explode in front of a client. The office had a name for the particular tone that meant a query had gone wrong: "the Monday voice." Nobody used it as a joke anymore by the time Adaeze had been there three years. It was



just what they called it, the way you'd name any other weather you couldn't control and had learned to plan around.

The nephew, to his credit, wasn't cruel about any of it. He was simply unprepared, and everyone in the building knew it, including him. He leaned on Adaeze constantly in his first year, quietly, off the books, because he needed her to actually run the branch while he held the title. She did it. She trained the person who had been placed above her, and Segun never once acknowledged that this was what was happening, because acknowledging it would have meant admitting his decision had needed a safety net.

I'm not going to spend this chapter explaining Segun's fear the way I've explained the others. He has one, and it's real; he was burned badly once by a trusted senior staff member who walked off with a client list, and he has never fully recovered his ability to extend trust to anyone he didn't raise himself. That's true. It's also not a good enough reason for what he does with it, and I'm not interested in building him a bridge back just because the reason behind the behaviour happens to be understandable.

Plenty of business owners get burned exactly once and come out the other side building better systems, clearer contracts, real accountability structures that don't depend on shared blood. Segun chose the cheaper fix. Family in the senior seats, volume in the meetings, and a floor full of competent people who have learned not to disagree with him twice.



We've been called into businesses that looked almost exactly like this one, small, about 23 staff, one dominant personality at the top who equates control with safety. The pattern is always recognisable within the first week, usually before we've even opened a file. Meetings that only move in one direction. A visible flinch when the owner's phone rings during a client call. A "family seat" or two that everyone routes around rather than through. The honest advice, in most of those engagements, is structural: real reporting lines, a second signature on anything above a set amount, an actual path for a competent outsider to earn a senior seat over time. We gave Segun that advice once, in a single meeting, at another business owner's request. He listened, nodded, and never called us again.

This is the one chapter in this book where I'm not going to hand you a reframe. Some bosses really are just protecting their own comfort and calling it protecting the business, and Segun is one of them. Adaeze left within the year. She's a finance manager at a bigger firm now, better paid, most assuredly better treated, and Segun's branch has cycled through three managers since, none of whom lasted eighteen months. He still hasn't asked himself why.

If you're working for someone like this, you may not need to find the useful question underneath his fear. Sometimes there isn't one waiting to be found. Sometimes the honest move is simply to leave, the way Adaeze did, without spending one more



year trying to understand a man who has shown you, repeatedly,
exactly what he is.



Chapter **Six**

The Boss Who Will Not Let You Grow



6

The Boss Who Will Not Let You Grow

Halimat had been the executive assistant to the MD of a real estate firm in Abuja for five years. She had asked, more than once, to be trained on the investment side of the business, to sit in on deal negotiations, to understand the numbers behind the deals she had spent years scheduling meetings about. Every time, her boss, Mr. Mohammed, found a reason to say no. "Not now." "Focus on what you're doing." "We'll talk about it later."

It's a common enough complaint that it's become a cliché on Nigerian career-advice Twitter: he's intimidated by what I could become. Sometimes that's exactly what's happening. This time, the truth sat somewhere stranger.

Halimat was, by Mohammed's own private accounting, the only person in the company who understood every moving part of his operation, every client relationship, every quiet arrangement with a contractor or a government office that kept the firm running in a sector where relationships mattered more than paperwork. No handover manual existed. No second-in-command. Losing the one person who held all of it together in her own head, mid-transition to something new, was not an



abstract fear for him. His answer wasn't really about her ceiling. It was about a gap he had no plan for closing, dressed up as a simple no because a simple no required nothing further from him. In essence, Halimat has been too good at her job for a promotion or upward change in job role.

Sometimes we see this in growing businesses, because at that size there's almost always one person like Halimat. Not the most senior title on paper, but the one who quietly holds the operation together, and the owner knows it, and the owner is terrified of it in a way he'd never phrase that plainly out loud. I worked with a logistics client whose dispatch coordinator was in exactly this position for six years, capped at the same role, the same pay, because the owner genuinely believed the business would fall apart within a month of promoting her out of it. It nearly did anyway, the day she finally quit without warning.

That's still not a good enough reason to leave someone stalled for five years. But a boss who trains a successor while training his best person into something bigger solves both problems at once. It is part of what we call succession planning. A boss who just keeps saying no solves neither, and eventually loses the very person he was trying to hold onto.

The dispatch coordinator I mentioned earlier didn't get that second version. She gave notice on a Wednesday, worked her final two weeks in near silence, and the business spent the next four months relearning, badly and expensively, everything she



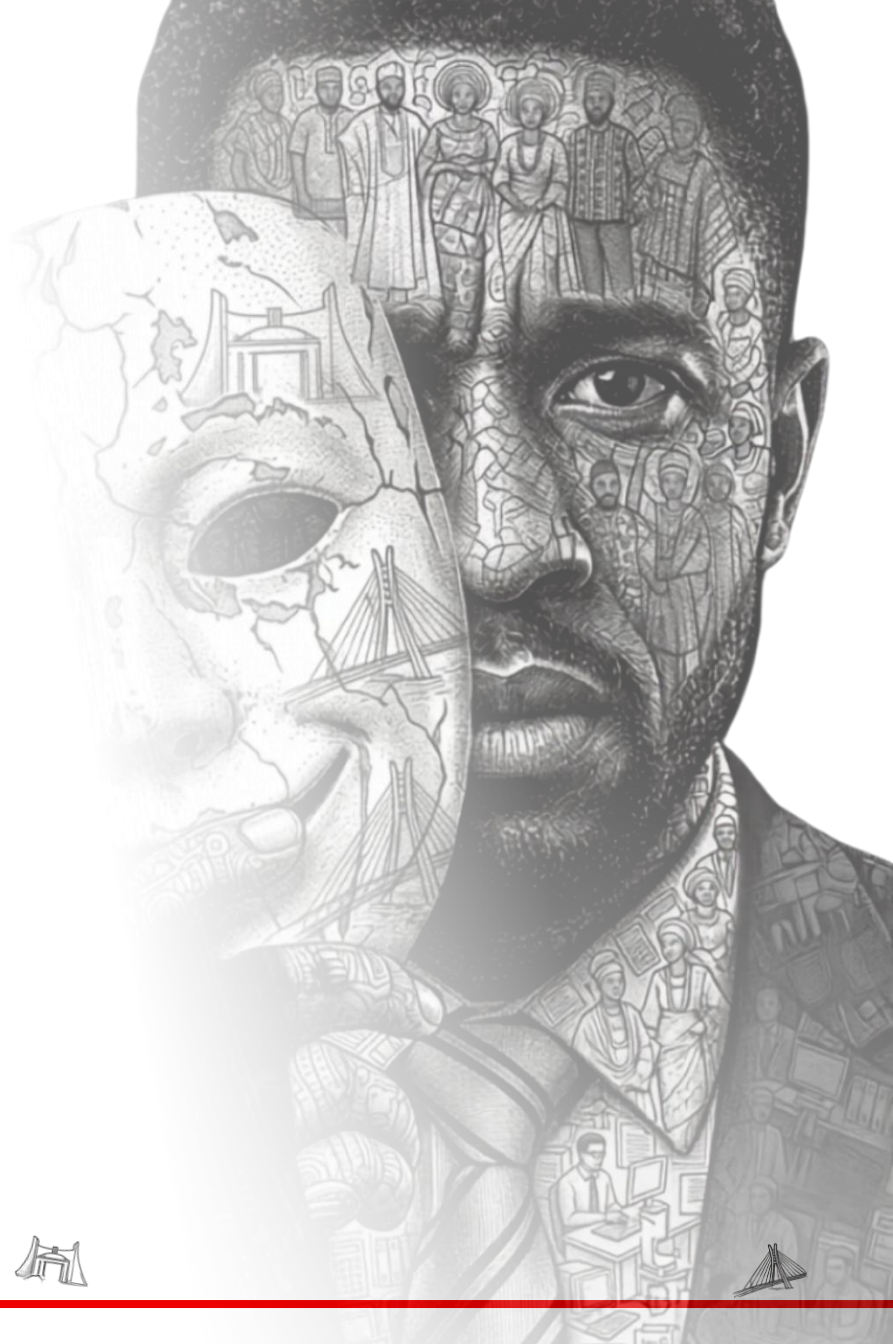
used to carry without anyone noticing the weight of it. Her old boss still tells that story as proof that you can't trust people with too much too soon. It's the same story. He just drew the wrong lesson from it, the way people often do when the lesson would cost them something to learn properly.

Halimat asked one more time, differently. Not "let me grow," but a plan: eight months, a documented handover, a junior hire trained in parallel to absorb the scheduling and admin work piece by piece. She wrote it out the night before, numbers and timelines attached, because "not now" is easy to say to a feeling and much harder to say to a plan with dates on it.

Mohammed read the page twice, in front of her. He asked two questions about the handover timeline and one about whether the junior hire would need market-rate pay, a question that told her more about what had actually been worrying him than five years of "not now" ever had. Then he said yes.

Within a year she was sitting in the room she'd spent years scheduling meetings for. The obstacle, once somebody put a shape to it, turned out to be smaller than either of them had assumed, which is so often the case with fears that have never once been said out loud in a room where they could be answered.





Postscript

Are Nigerian Bosses *Really* Bad?

Ask Ifeoma's colleague what he makes of Mr. Adisa, and you'll hear something else entirely: that man taught me how to run a tight operation, I wouldn't have survived starting my own business without it. Ask the client whose account got saved by a founder who pushed her team past their comfort, and you won't hear "difficult." You'll hear that she's never once let them be embarrassed in front of their own customers.

Same person. Different desk to view them from.

That's not an argument that every difficult boss is secretly misunderstood. One of the Chapters in this book exists precisely because some of them aren't. Some bosses are genuinely careless with the people who depend on them, genuinely more interested in their own comfort than anyone else's, and no amount of context about the naira or the courts changes that fact when it's the actual fact in front of you. This book hasn't tried to prove every bad-boss story hides a good reason. Only that a lot of them do, more often than the angry version usually admits, and that telling the two apart is a skill worth having.

I've built a career on sitting in the middle of exactly this question, brought into businesses precisely because a founder and their staff have stopped being able to see each other clearly. Almost every engagement starts the same way: a founder



convinced their team isn't working hard enough, and a team convinced their founder doesn't see them at all. Both are usually a little right. Neither has the full picture, because nobody in the building has ever had a reason to sit down and compare them side by side. That comparison is most of what I actually get paid to do.

Not every business I walk into wants to hear that. Some founders want a consultant to confirm that the problem is entirely the staff, and some staff want a consultant to confirm that the problem is entirely the founder. The engagements that actually change anything are the ones where somebody, usually the person paying my invoice, is willing to sit still long enough to hear that the honest answer sits in the middle, and that fixing it will cost them something, whether that's a habit, a family seat, or a story they've been telling themselves for years.

The difference between the two readings changes what you do next, and that matters more for your life than for your boss's reputation. Resigning at midnight in fury is one path. Asking the calm question the next morning, when you can actually hear the answer, is another. Sometimes the question confirms what you already suspected, and the honest move is to leave, with your dignity intact. More often than the group chats admit, the question reveals somebody doing their genuine best inside pressures you were never shown, pressures that, once you see them, make the decision look less like malice and more like the



ordinary, imperfect choices anyone makes while trying to keep something they built from falling apart.

Nigerian business is simply hard, in ways most leadership advice was never built to account for. Currency shocks. Power that turns every working day into its own small negotiation. Margins thinned by taxes from multiple directions at once. Institutions that rarely protect the small operator the way they're supposed to, leaving each one to invent their own private, imperfect system for staying alive. The bosses who make it through that intact get shaped by it, and the shape often looks, from where an employee stands, exactly like meanness, or indecision, or an unreasonable Saturday, or a door that stays closed for four years too long.

Not every boss deserves that reading. Some just need to be left. But most of the time, the real work isn't settling, once and for all, whether your particular boss belongs in the good column or the bad one. It's holding both at once: the pressure they're carrying that you mostly can't see, and the pressure they hand down that you can, clearly enough to know when to push back, when to wait a little longer, and when it's simply time to let somebody else stand in your place and discover, from there, an entirely different boss than the one you knew.

None of the people in this book read a page of it before it was written, and most of them will never know they're in it. Names changed, details softened, a location moved here and there,



enough that nobody still working in these industries gets exposed by a story that was never meant to embarrass anyone specifically. But the patterns are not invented. I've sat across from versions of Mr. Adisa, Amaka, Mrs. Ponzing, Jude, Segun, and Mohammed more times than I can count, in businesses smaller than most people would guess from the outside, run by people doing their genuine best with what fear and circumstance handed them. Some of them earned the sympathy this book gives them. One of them, deliberately, did not.

Run your own race. Trust your process where it's earned trust, and leave where it hasn't. Your time is here.





Prince Elijah Abumoye is an HR and business consultant based in Nigeria. He holds a BSc from the University of Lagos and has served as Chief Operating Officer and Country Head of HR for multinational operations across Nigeria, Rwanda, and Dubai. He is the founder of

Traction Outsourcing Limited, Traction Properties & Managers, and ATH Recruiters, and works with businesses on the gap between what a founder needs and what a team believes it's already delivering. He is the author of ***Nigerian Bosses Are Bad***.

